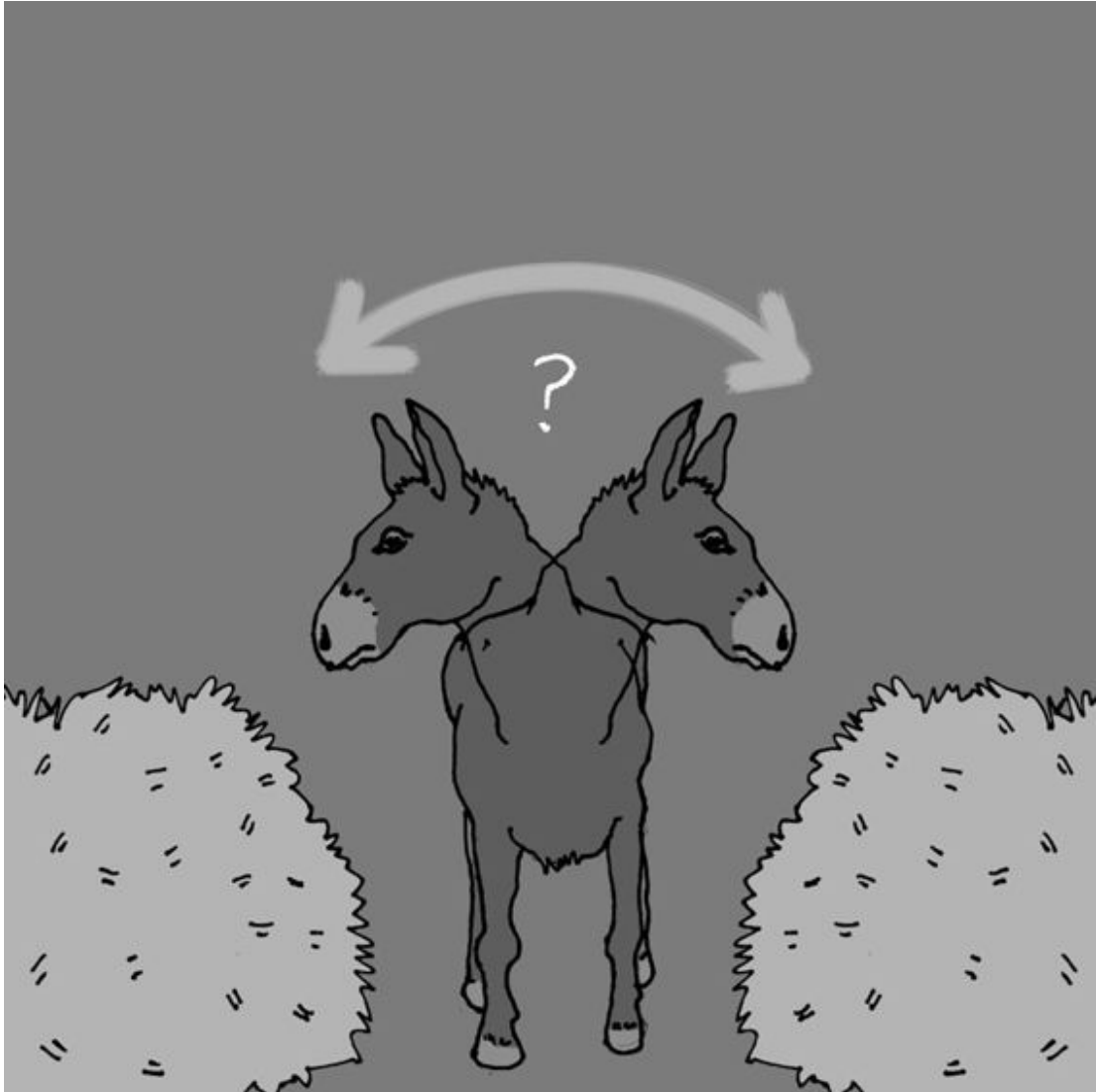


Ockham's razor and Buridan's ass

William of Ockham wrote widely on scientific subjects and logic as well as philosophy and theology. He maintained a distinction between matters of faith and what we would now call science, but was eventually excommunicated from the Church for heresy. Heavily influenced by Aristotle, he believed in using the evidence of observation and experience as a basis for rational arguments, anticipating the later 'scientific method'.

He is perhaps best known for the principle known as Ockham's razor: when there are two alternative explanations for something, all things being equal, the simpler explanation is more likely to be correct. We should 'shave off' unnecessary assumptions and choose the explanation with the fewest causes, factors or variables. Ockham's pupil Jean Buridan lent his name to a different paradox of rational choice between alternatives. Buridan's ass is a hungry beast placed exactly halfway between two equally attractive bales of hay. Unable to choose between the two, it eventually starves to death.



When faced with two equally convincing arguments, we run the risk of choosing neither, when in fact it makes no difference so long as we make a decision.